

“The old Allahabad is losing its identity and is being systematically dismantled.”

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Writer



The Civil Lines of today cannot be compared to what it was about even 25 years ago, when the elite of the city would frequent this place. Now, the roadside buildings are plastered with screaming billboards and hoardings; unrestricted vehicular traffic is a daily madness even as cows elbow traffic policemen out and occupy traffic islands. The presence of criminal elements in this upmarket locality can't go unnoticed—the demolition in August 2007 of a huge market complex is a glaring example of rampant illegal construction. Vira D. Gandhi, related to the first family of Indian politics, was all set to lose his multi-crore building in Civil Lines to a mafia don, had Congress President Sonia Gandhi not personally intervened.

Amidst this chaotic scenario, the famous Coffee House still serves like an oasis in the desert. If the Nehrus and the Lohias hotly debated national issues here in the days gone by, politicians of the present age do spend some time at this famous address to satiate their intellectual appetite. “Unfortunately, an era has come when Allahabad has lost its participation in the national politics,” says senior BJP leader and former Assembly speaker Keshari Nath Tripathi. Allahabad has produced stalwarts like Motilal Nehru, Jawaharlal Nehru,

Ram Manohar Lohia and, post-Independence, Indira Gandhi and Vishwanath Pratap Singh, to name a few.

This situation leaves the likes of Anugrah Narain Singh, Congress MLA from Allahabad City North constituency, struggling to make their voice heard. Singh is the first legislator in the country to have returned his ‘Vidhayak Nidhi’ (Rs 1.25 crore annual development fund allocated to MLAs) to the Government, alleging misappropriation of the money. “I know that a major portion of the fund is being eaten up by criminals and contractors, so why should I receive it?” says Singh, who still uses a scooter to get around. He has demanded a high-level inquiry into the utilisation of the Vidhayak Nidhi and the parallel scheme for MPs to expose what he calls an unholy nexus between politicians and criminal-contractors and squandering of public money in the name of development.

Allahabad had been at the centre of India's struggle for independence and then a key contributor to national politics by sending three prime ministers—Jawaharlal, Indira and Vishwanath—who had deep roots in the city. If it was a strong bastion of the Congress so was it for the communist movement (like P.C. Joshi) and the socialists of the stature of Lohia.



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